# Democracy and the Four Freedoms:

## A Ledger Account

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**Abstract**

This paper argues that democracy is not fundamentally a mechanism for selecting rulers, but a mechanism for aggregating claims over the ledger. For this aggregation to be genuine, it must rest upon the preconditions that allow actors to contest their terms of relation without fear of disproportionate reprisal. Through the lens of the ledger framework, Franklin D. Roosevelt's Four Freedoms (freedom of speech and expression, freedom of worship, freedom from want, and freedom from fear) are shown to be structural necessities rather than aspirational rights. Freedom of speech and worship expand voice ($v_i^e$), freedom from want lowers exit costs ($k_i^e$) by providing viable alternatives to coercive relations, and freedom from fear prevents the substitution of repression for legitimacy. When these freedoms are eroded, politics atomizes, voice is captured, and democracy decays into a nominal form whilst the ledger remains skewed towards the sustaining coalition.

**Keywords:** democracy, four freedoms, ledger, voice, exit costs, legitimacy, aggregation, political contestation

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# 1 Introduction

Democracy is commonly defined as rule by the people. Whilst intuitively appealing, this definition obscures more than it reveals. Who counts as "the people" at any given time is itself a product of political contestation. Furthermore, the act of voting is only one moment within a far broader process of contestation over the terms of social, economic, and political life [4, 10].

From the vantage of the ledger framework, democracy is best understood as an institutional attempt to aggregate claims ($P(S)$) over the state of the ledger $S$. For claims to be aggregated truthfully, actors must be able to propose alternatives to the status quo without incurring existential costs for doing so. This precondition is structural. It requires that the parameters of the ledger are set such that voice is not performative, exit is not illusory, and contestation is not penalized into silence [1, 2].

It is precisely these preconditions that President Franklin D. Roosevelt articulated in his 1941 State of the Union address as the Four Freedoms: freedom of speech and expression, freedom of worship, freedom from want, and freedom from fear [9]. This paper argues that these freedoms are not decorative add-ons to democracy, but the material and structural foundations upon which democratic aggregation rests.

# 2 The Ledger Preconditions of Democratic Aggregation

For a system to be democratically aggregative, three conditions must hold simultaneously.

1. **Genuine voice.** Actors must possess the capacity to articulate grievances and propose alternatives. As established in the ledger framework, asymmetries in $v_i^e$ skew bargaining power, rendering politics endogenous to the ledger [2]. If voice is monopolized, claims fail to enter circulation within $P(S)$.

2. **Viable exit.** The threat of exit must be credible, and more importantly, alternatives must be livable. If $k_i^e \to \infty$ for a class of actors, their only option is acceptance or revolt, breaking the bargaining symmetry required for legitimate contestation [5, 2].

3. **Low cost of contestation.** The cost of politics must be lower than the cost of acceptance beneath the rupture threshold. When contestation is met with disproportionate surveillance, blacklisting, or coercion, legitimacy erodes and governments substitute repression for compliance, raising the cost of governance $\Phi(G, L)$ [1, 13].

Democracy fails not when people argue, but when the parameters of the ledger make arguing futile, dangerous, or impossible. The Four Freedoms are the institutional response to each of these failures.

# 3 The Four Freedoms in Ledger Terms

## 3.1 Freedom of Speech and Expression

The freedom to speak, publish, and assemble is the institutionalization of voice. Without it, grievances are forced underground, claims are filtered by gatekeepers, and the set $P(S)$ no longer reflects the interests of the governed.

This is more than a liberty, but a condition for discovery. Dissent reveals the true shape of $G(S)$, exposing the distance between the realized ledger and the viability set $V$. A democracy

that criminalizes its critics does not merely silence speech, it destroys its own ability to perceive the injustice gap that it must govern [6, 2].

### 3.2 Freedom of Worship

Conscience is non-negotiable for genuine contestation. The freedom of worship protects the right to derive obligations from sources outside of the coalition that sustains the government. This prevents the fusion of $G$ and the sacred, a fusion which, historically, has been used to naturalize the status quo as the will of God and to render reallocation blasphemous [12, 3].

In ledger terms, this protects an independent source of legitimacy. It widens the space of justification beyond the coalition's preferred narrative, allowing actors to contest shares ($s_i^e$) on grounds that are not granted by the apparatus Org itself.

### 3.3 Freedom From Want

Of the four, this is the most material. Want is a coercive force. An actor facing starvation, eviction, or the denial of basic care has an effective exit cost $k_i^e \approx \infty$ with respect to any relation that could provide their subsistence, no matter how extractive it is.

Freedom from want is, therefore, the project of lowering the floor of desperation. Universal access to necessities, robust public goods, and a social minimum all function to expand the set of viable alternatives. By doing so, they equalize the bargaining position between actors and allow voice ($v_i^e$) to be exercised freely, rather than under duress. Material security is not charity to democracy, it is a precondition for its symmetry [11, 2].

### 3.4 Freedom From Fear

Fear is the mechanism by which atomization is enforced without explicit prohibition of speech. Surveillance, arbitrary enforcement, paramilitary intimidation, and selective prosecution all serve to raise the private cost of contestation far above its public penalty.

This directly attacks legitimacy. A government that must rely upon fear to maintain compliance is, by Proposition 4.4 of the ledger framework, in the process of substituting repression for legitimacy, causing $\Phi(G, L)$ to rise exponentially [1, 14]. Freedom from fear is, thus, the prohibition on the transformation of governance into coercion. It preserves the distinction between justified enforcement of the ledger, and the use of the apparatus to suppress claims against it.

## 4 Democracy as the Institutionalization of These Freedoms

A democracy is not measured by the regularity of its elections alone, but by its capacity to uphold these four freedoms between and during them. Electoral cycles are necessary, but insufficient.

Institutions such as an independent press, protected assembly, freedom of religion, an impartial judiciary, robust labor protections, public goods, and constraints upon the security apparatus all exist to lock these freedoms into the structure of $\text{Gov} = (G,\ \text{Org})$. Their purpose is to prevent the coalition from capturing the very freedoms that allow it to be challenged [7, 4].

Crucially, these are self-reinforcing. Freedom of speech reveals the need for freedom from want. Freedom from want enables freedom of worship to be a genuine choice rather than a product of desperation. Freedom from fear creates the space for all three to be exercised collectively. Together, they keep the ledger open to rebalancing.

## 5 When the Freedoms Erode

The decay of democracy is almost always the erosion of these freedoms, not their abolition in name.

- **Voice captured:** Consolidation of media, SLAPP suits, and the criminalization of protest throttle $P(S)$ whilst maintaining the appearance of debate.
- **Conscience constrained:** Majoritarian nationalism or the fusion of party and faith pressures conformity, blurring the line between loyalty to the coalition and loyalty to the polity.
- **Desperation weaponized:** Precarity, wage stagnation, and the gutting of public goods raise $k_i^e$ for the majority whilst simultaneously lowering them for the mobile factor, replicating the exit asymmetry that captures government [8].
- **Fear normalized:** Mass surveillance, militarized policing, and discretionary enforcement create a chilling effect. Politics becomes a matter of safety, not principle, driving atomization and suppressing the very claims that would correct the injustice gap [14].

In such a configuration, the form of democracy persists, but its substance collapses into what the ledger framework terms *government without sovereignty*: formally democratic, yet structurally oligarchic, implementing a $\lambda$ vector skewed towards the sustaining coalition [1].

## 6 Conclusion

Democracy's legitimacy rests upon its ability to aggregate claims over an ever-changing ledger. This ability is conditional. Freedom of speech and worship secure the right to contest. Freedom from want secures the ability to do so on equal footing. Freedom from fear secures the safety to do so at all.

These are not luxuries of prosperity, but the parameters of democratic politics themselves. To defend democracy is, first and foremost, to defend these freedoms. To expand democracy is to expand them to those for whom they remain, in practice, illusory. The Four Freedoms are, therefore, not the goals that follow democracy, but the foundations that make democracy possible to begin with.

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